Gaza. “Our aim is to bring all of them home.” Will that postpone the imminent ground offensive?

Saturday, October 21

Humanitarian aid was allowed to enter Gaza today through the Rafah crossing. Strangely, UN and other humanitarian sources confirm that the shipments did not undergo any screenings for weapons or other contraband before entering the enclave. In Israel, the twenty-fifth American cargo plane landed with military and medical equipment.

American and Israeli officials are considering various political futures for Gaza after the elimination of Hamas. Among such possibilities, they envisage a temporary government with some form of UN participation and the support of Arab countries. How this support might be achieved, nobody knows for the time being. The Americans seem to be worried by Israel’s focus on short-term military objectives, without sufficient thought being given to what could happen after these objectives are achieved. President Biden, during his trip to Israel, warned of repeating the mistakes the US made after 9/11.

Even the best postwar preparations cannot ensure that the ground offensive in Gaza will lead to a good outcome. Without such a ground offensive Hamas cannot be destroyed, and if it is not destroyed it will claim victory and repeat an October 7–style operation in due course. But the ground offensive may, under the existing conditions in the Muslim world, draw in Hamas’s allies and its patron Iran, which in turn will necessitate American involvement. And what the sequels of an American involvement may be, no one can predict.

Israel has evacuated about 300,000 civilians from communities near the Gaza border in the South and the Lebanon border in the North. It has suffered approximately 1,400 deaths since Hamas unleashed its attack. The